Arkhipov had questions of his own. The commanders of each of his submarines took an unusual weapon on board: one of their twenty-two torpedoes was nuclear-tipped with a charge equal to ten kilotons of TNT, two-thirds of the destructive power of the Hiroshima bomb. According to the commander of another of Arkhipov's four submarines, Captain Second Grade Riurik Ketov, Arkhipov asked one of the senior commanders of the Northern Fleet at the meeting: "It's not clear to us why we are taking atomic weapons along." "That's the directive," came the answer. "You should familiarize yourself with it [i.e., the weapon]." Arkhipov was not satisfied with that reply. "Fine," he continued, "but when and how should we use it?" The question was met with silence. The senior commanders had no clear answers. The captains of Arkhipov's submarines were confused, at least when it came to their memories of the orders they had received concerning nuclear weapons.

Captain Ketov later recalled an oral order from the chief of staff of the Northern Fleet, Admiral Anatoly Rassokho: "Use the special weapon in the following cases. First, if you are bombed and there is a breach in the pressure hull. Second, if you surface and come under fire and, again, if there is a breach. And third, on orders from Moscow!" Captain Dubivko recalled a written order that read: "Use standard weapons on orders from the Commander in Chief of the Soviet Navy or in case of an armed attack on the vessel. Torpedos with nuclear warheads are to be used only on special orders from the USSR Ministry of Defense or the Commander in Chief of the Soviet Navy." It would appear that every captain had his own understanding of what he could do with his single nuclear torpedo.[6]

While Arkhipov had many questions regarding the mission, he also had some answers. He was one of the very few people to be told immediately the final destination of the submarines—Mariel Bay on the northwestern shore of Cuba. Arkhipov and his group of submarines followed a course from the Barents Sea to the Norwegian Sea and then through the North Atlantic toward the Azores, and from there toward the Bahamas.

The submarines were supposed to reach Cuba covertly, without being detected, but the Moscow planners had little idea of how that could be accomplished. Some believed that Moscow did not fully realize that the submarines dispatched to Cuba were powered by diesel engines, not nuclear